Despite following the training schedule that every apprentice did, Ratan was always looking for more interesting things to do. One day, after his training hours, his inquisitiveness got the better of him. Brimming with energy, he climbed the tallest chimney on the shop floor to enjoy the view. When he had looked at the chimney from below, climbing it looked like a cakewalk to someone accustomed to flying planes. The bare iron steps and railing that snaked their way to the top of the chimney appeared simple. Apparently, he had overestimated his courage.

Ratan recalls amusedly: 'I got to the top and I was petrified as I didn't know how to come down. I was terrified.' He looked down to see if he could hail someone for help, but there was no one in sight. Finally, he mustered the courage and clambered down, steadying his trembling legs, descending one rung at a time, vowing never to test his adventurous spirit in this manner ever again.

Ratan was paid a monthly stipend of Rs 800. As he recalls, even this modest remuneration was too much as there was nothing to spend for him the money on. The housing provided to him was austere. He stayed in the apprentice hall, where the dealers from around the country who came for training in marketing were housed. He lived in a double room on the ground floor that was sparsely appointed. Two built-in almirahs stood out as the most notable of the conveniences provided to the trainees. There was no attached bathroom either. He had to make do with one at the end of the corridor and would often wait his turn to use it, particularly in the mornings. He had to sleep without an air conditioner in a town that is generally hot throughout the year and where the humidity is particularly oppressive.

After six months at TELCO, Ratan moved to TISCO where he spent over five years. TISCO was the result of Jamsetji's most enduring dream to establish a steel plant. Initially scorned by the British, his idea met approval after a meeting with Lord George Hamilton, the secretary of state for India. Lord Hamilton was impressed with Jamsetji and wrote to Viceroy Lord Curzon to support the establishment of a steel plant. Although Jamsetji passed away before his plan reached fruition, three years after his death, TISCO was established in 1907 under his son Sir Dorabji.

Here, life was more organized. At the steel plant, the trainers and supervisory staff were also keen to train Ratan. They enthusiastically explained the process of steelmaking to him and tried hard to satisfy his inquisitive mind. Some of the most interesting experiences were related to